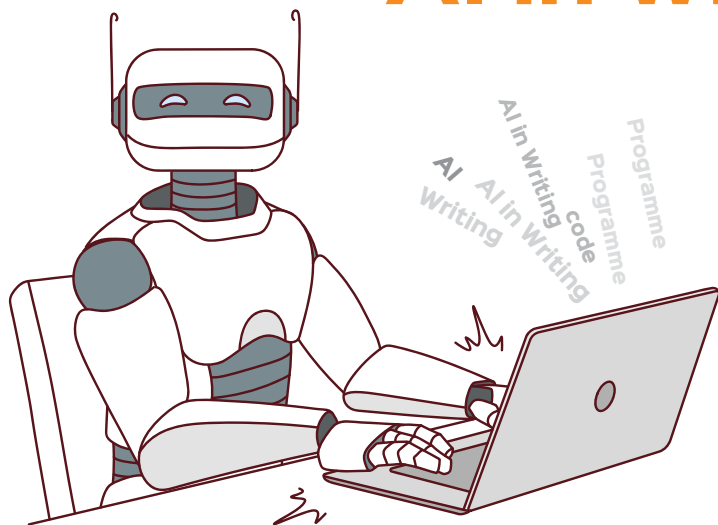


The Pitfalls of Using AI in Writing



The fact that generative AI software is open source does not make a difference. There can be no pride in creating content that anyone can create. The author opines that AI-generated or AI-enhanced content is, essentially, content stolen from other publishers.

The famous *Sports Illustrated* magazine was recently caught publishing AI-generated articles, complete with AI-generated photos for the profiles of its non-existent authors (<https://www.theguardian.com/media/2023/nov/28/sports-illustrated-ai-writers>). It was quite a fall from grace. If you are any kind of writer or if you indulge in any kind of publishing (including even software documentation), this incident should make you pause to think. Should you believe the hype and get help from AI?

What is AI? Is it not just software?

Many years ago, I decided to make one last update to software that I had created many more years ago. By then, there were hundreds of software download sites where my software could be hosted/listed. Rather than submit my software to each one of them manually, I decided to use the trial version of a mass-submission tool. For each software download website, the tool would programmatically download the software submission page, create an account in my name if required, and upload my program details and/or the download file. The website would then create a download page based on the submitted metadata. Some websites had a Google captcha filter to foil such automated submissions. The submission tool solved most of the captcha images on its own. It transparently showed the downloading of the captcha image and its attempts to solve them. It was successful most of the times but for the rest it asked me to intervene. When I manually solved a captcha, it would resume the submission process. I was amazed how well the software worked. This was a decade ago.

How did the software solve the captcha image? Artificial intelligence? Not at all. Artificial intelligence is just software. There are image-recognition software that can read text from photos. These software have been bundled with printers and scanners for at least two decades now. After open source alternatives for such proprietary software became more easily available (in places such as GitHub), programmers began to modularise and use them in myriad applications. Now, some of these applications tend to amaze and they are treated as 'AI'.

The early AI applications were based on a limited data set from which they could form their logic. With the World Wide Web, the data set for self-learning has become practically unlimited. All kinds of text, audio and video are being uploaded to the web. Microsoft and Google have scanned millions of library books. Their search engines, which legally and illegally parse this data, can create AI programs that can seem astonishingly powerful. But, it is still old technology. Microsoft Word has been able to detect bad grammar for more than two decades. What is different today for AI programs is the size of the data set that they can leverage.

AI-generated content may seem beautiful but it is still a Frankenstein monster

Electronic music synthesisers are an early example of an AI device based on a limited data set. Using a sound bank of recordings, they could imitate many man-made musical instruments. They could also create electronically-generated waveforms that no traditional musical instrument could possibly create. Electronic keyboards may have spurred a music revolution but they did not make musical instruments